Artists in Communities and Schools Projects

Purpose

https://www.arts.on.ca/grants/artists-in-communities-and-schools-projects

The program has three categories:

Planning: to help cover the costs of co-planning and co-designing community-engaged arts projects.
Project: to help cover the costs of realizing community-engaged arts projects.
Two-year project: This category is available to community-engaged arts collectives and organizations that have received two or more OAC project grants through community-engaged arts or arts education grant programs within the last five years. Activities must take place over the period of two years.

Mentorship: up to $3,000 in additional funds are available in any category to cover the costs involved in mentoring professional artists from OAC priority groups, to build their skills and experience in project planning and/or facilitating community-engaged arts projects.

Applicants may be either mentors or mentees.
Mentees must be professional artists and members of at least one OAC priority group.
The names of mentors and mentees must be included in the application along with artistic examples of their work and their CVs.

Project Plans

What are you planning to do, and what do you want to achieve with this project?
[Maximum 425 words]

Developing a plan for the co-creation of a theatre work, in community, by theatre artist Robin Moir and visual artist/educator Sally Lawrence. The planning phase anticipates the production of an original musical theatre folk opera etc by Robin alongside two communities Sally lives and works in - The Forest Courtyard Initiative, a small rural alternative Waldorf-Inspired forest/farm school near Tottenham, north of Toronto; and Hesperus Fellowship, an independent living retirement community in Thornhill with a diverse social group where senior residents are invited to take initiative, explore, develop and share their gifts while cultivating meaningful relationships that is home to many artists, educators, and in Thornhill. Through the planning period, the artists (Sally and Robin) will develop the initial content to be presented to the community stakeholders. The implementation of the plan developed in this period will result in co-creating the work with the participants from both the communities using a variety of creative methodologies, from devised theatre, to crafting, song writing circles, creative movement and other workshops.

The planning phase is crucial to lay the foundation for the co-creative process: Robin will continue developing a storyboard for the narrative, fleshing out characters and writing three to five initial musical numbers to establish the work's sonic aesthetic; Sally will build out a curriculum to guide participation, structuring the flow of co-creation for the eventual participants - as well as establishing visual motifs for the collaborative artistic production to follow. Both artists will maintain communication in the form of monthly meetings with the stakeholders at the retirement community and school - ensuring buy-in for the project beyond the planning phase.

The theatre piece itself is currently in the initial stages of conceptualization by Robin, as a work about Norse mythology, specifically focusing on the narratives of female characters from within the folklore. The piece builds off their previous production, *A Song For Hephaestus*, a folk opera which used Greek mythology as a lens through which to explore narratives about disability, injustice, and the liberatory potential of creative labour. Robin uses well known mythological characters and stories combined with rich songwriting to empower the participants in their work alongside audiences. In Spring/Summer 2025, Robin and Sally staged two productions of *A Song For Hephaestus* at Forest Courtyard Initiative and the Toronto Waldorf School, adapted for children aged 7 - 13. Following those successful productions, the two artists engaged in the co-creation of a musical theatre work that explored the stories of four major Abrahamic religions (Judaism, Christianity, Islam, Baha'i Faith) through original songs and popular music, structured into a narrative that was performed by children at the Forest Courtyard School.

The initiative that results from this plan, will build from those successful productions, with the goal of creating a new work that uses well-known mythological narratives to tell new stories that will resonate with both the youth at the school and elderly at the retirement community

Outline your work plan for this project below. The following information is required:

Start date - November 11th, 2026
End date - March 11th, 2027
Project activity/task(s) - Robin - 10 hours of work per week for 16-18 weeks ($40/hr?) - meeting biweekly with Sally Lawrence to be mentored and plan the events, etc.
Location of activity (venue, city, province, country) - Hesperus Fellowship in Thornhill ON and Forest Courtyard Initiative in Tottenham, ON (Canada) & virtually meeting
Person(s) and/or organization(s) involved - Robin Moir (artist) and Sally Lawrence as liaison between the artist and the organizations - Hesperus Fellowship and Forest Courtyard Initiative

If you plan to involve other people or organizations in your project, list them below. [Maximum 20 rows]

The following information is required:

Name
Sally Lawrence
City/town/First Nation where they live/are located (if outside Ontario, enter province and/or country)
Thornhill
Role on project
Mentor & Coordinator
Is the person or organization paid for their work/participation in your project?
Yes

Name
Forest Courtyard initiative
City/town/First Nation where they live/are located (if outside Ontario, enter province and/or country)
Tottenham
Role on project
Host Organization for youth workshops
Is the person or organization paid for their work/participation in your project?
No

Name **Hesperus Village**
City/town/First Nation where they live/are located (if outside Ontario, enter province and/or country)
Role on project
Support Organization for community workshops

Is the person or organization paid for their work/participation in your project?
No

Why have you chosen, or how will you choose, the people and/or organizations you will work with? How will you work with them and what will they contribute to the project? [Maximum 400 words]

- I have a history of working with both the Forest Courtyard Initiative and the Hesperus Fellowship community,
- have developed lasting, positive relationships with these communities
- There is a desire for growth, learning, community creation, and bringing people together in these spaces, room for exploration and creativity
- Forest Courtyard Initiative - holistic, developmental, nature, community, art… based education… my work in mythology and folklore fit well within the curriculum
- Sally Lawrence is the lead teacher for the grade 2-7 children and has a plethora of knowledge to share as an artist, educator, and community leader - having her act as liaison between artist and organizations
- - Hesperus is situated as a creative hub - home to many retired intellectuals, artists, educators - with a wide variety of lived experience and knowledge to share - from all over the world and has a history of upholding the arts
- I've done care work, performed at monthly soirees, worked on plays etc with these people and there is much to learn here…
- - Hesperus, as a secondary organization, to help as leaders in the community, would help guide the project into something truly special
- HOW WE WILL WORK WITH THEM:
- I will develop song writing circles, crafting nights, skill sharing, and theatre devising workshops, as well as experimental sharing soirees… and two community preview performances to engage with the wider community so that families and friends of participants can share ideas - give and take
- Students at the school will be working on curriculum that compliments the work in this project
- WHAT THEY WILL CONTRIBUTE TO THE PROJECT:
- Provide space for events, volunteers provide snacks for events, provide community to participate and marketing to bring in more people…
- (not enough words)

What audiences, participants, communities, partners and artists do you intend to reach?

- rural youth and their families being connected to retired elder creatives and intellectuals (from all over the world) living in suburban GTA and their families…
- bringing together two communities…

What immediate and ongoing benefits do you expect the project will have for them? [Maximum 450 words]

- Sally Lawrence working as lead teacher, as liaison… and as mentor to Robin…would be both convenient and very rich for the children and other community participants - as she would be able to tie the learning and creation we do in the community into the children's education
- this opportunity could be life changing for the children getting to be at the centre of the work
- Many of the same children have been in the productions Robin and Sally put on at Forest Courtyard for the past two years and have an established relationship… but this opportunity would allow for the learning and creation to go so much deeper
- the children could be fully immersed in the mythology and surrounding history and folklore, they would be learning real world skills, learning that they are capable of creating big things, that their ideas can be manifested into becoming tangible and having impact on their communities - showing them they can make an impact and they can make change happen
- these children would also benefit from having more elder examples to learn from
- The guidance from the elder community members at Hesperus has the ability to give the children new perspective and wisdom….
- Intergenerational wisdom-sharing and reverence for the knowledge of the older generations are a necessity that is sorely lacking in our society
- with Sally Lawrence as also acting liaison (who has lived and worked with the people of Hesperus since 2010?)
- Also a huge benefit for the Hesperus residents to have time with young children, fulfilling mentorship roles, being given opportunities to play and explore new concepts and ideas from the younger generations, while being uplifted as community leaders
- (not enough words)

What are your plans to reach your intended audience, participants or community? [Maximum 225 words]

- Marketing and outreach through Sally Lawrence and partner organizations - would be able to bring these stories to groups that are interested in these message
- Hesperus, Sally, FCI also have connections to other schools in the area, for bigger events could bring in more people as the communities come together and grow
- Intergenerational… different events geared towards different groups
- Workshops focused on music creation, on lyric writing and word play, on building the aesthetics of the world, devised theatre creation - building the world and understanding the characters and their unique voices, crafting props and set pieces from conception…
- The planning phase will give us so much of the necessary time and resources needed to put everything in place so that we can bring together these communities - with time to drum up excitement and intrigue at Hesperus and Forest Courtyard
- So that there is already investment before we begin working on anything concrete
- Sally Lawrence will share the stories of norse mythology with the children at the forest courtyard school and show them pitch deck, storyboard, song examples as Robin is

creating them - in this way, the students will be in collaboration with the piece before they have started formally taking part in the full-blown creation

- These seeds can also be planted in the Hesperus community over the next 4-5 months - as Sally can bring interest to Robin - who at Hesperus would like to be a community leader in this project and what they are either established in / have a wealth of knowledge about that they wish to share (song writers assisting in leading song circles, and authors helping with writing workshops, visual artists guiding craft-making and world building…) or if they have a desire to learn a new skill
- These opportunities to share their craft and/or learn new skills will build great excitement at Hesperus while Norse mythology being baked into the FCI curriculum taught by Sally Lawrence will get the students' imaginations going and give them lots of time to come up with their own ideas and offerings by the time the spring comes… and we move into the full project…
- (too many words)

Describe how the safety and well-being (physical, emotional, social, or other) of all involved in the project is addressed in your project plan. [Maximum 250 words]

- This is an important part of the part of the planning phase - working with FCI to ensure we have an accessible space for Hesperites…
- Physical Safety and accessibility - ongoing work with the school and retirement community bringing together… to establish needs - a living document - assessing who wants to be involved and making space accessible to all who want to be involved
- Mobility needs** making rehearsal, workshop, performance spaces accessible to those with mobility issues - step free access? Space for wheelchairs? Comfortable seating close to the stage (also for people with visual and hearing impairment to be close enough to understand and be a part of the events)
- Following protocols - pacing things with extra time for breaks, moments for pause and rest, time to drink water, stay hydrated, having assistant teachers from FCI do check ins to ensure everyone is well and not over-exerting
- Public health protocols followed (stay home if sick, sanitize hands, working in spaces with proper air circulation
- Legal safeguards - chaperone and staff ratios, school staff and facilitators required to have vulnerable sector/criminal record checks… people on staff with first aid training for added safety…
- We can designate someone who participants can go to if they're uncomfortable, feel unsafe, or have additional needs - can be done confidentially
- Emotional safety - Bringing people together - forging connections and actively fighting emotional isolation…. Project designed to build safety through community in this way (isolation reduction)
- Collective creation fights hierarchy - psychological safeties in place… breaking down hierarchy and power imbalances - equality of everyone's voice and a methodology that highlights shared authorship and aims to lift up all voices

- Prepare students for how to work with elders… (“structured intergenerational orientation”) social and cultural wellbeing… and vice versa - how to be sensitive to each other
- “Vulnerability safeguards” - boundaries for story gathering - it will all be combined into a greater whole, specifics shared will be anonymous - no personal stories, etc, used in the work, etc
- “Right to pass” - allowed to sit out…
- Boundaries set clearly before start - behavioural code of conduct - touch, personal space, language - what is acceptable - laid out clearly with check ins
- (too many words - almost 100 over)

Background

Tell us about who you are as an artist, arts professional, group or organization. [Maximum 300 words]

I am a multidisciplinary artist, musician, theatre creator and filmmaker. I also have experience working as an educator, guide, storyteller, etc

- As a queer, neurodivergent person living with invisible disabilities… growing up in poverty in rural communities and being exposed to people of all walks of life, backgrounds, and income brackets as I travelled and grew as an artist, I’ve had a lot of experience inhabiting a variety of spaces, fitting myself into them like a chameleon yet never feeling quite like I belonged… finding spaces where each person in the community is lifted up through expression - not brought down by the weight of perfectionism, but given the tools to emancipate themselves through the process of creation
- Exploring being othered, how it feels to be on the outside of societal norms - and seeing how every person experiences this to different degrees - whether through race, gender, sexuality, income inequality, disability, trauma, etc - how our differences, what we do not understand about each other can always be a key into understanding more about the not only each other but also world around us and ourselves.
- Deepening empathy through creative work
- I am going to tell you a story: a lie made of truth - how can mythology and fiction explain simple truths to an audience, to a community, even to the creators of the work? How can a story or a piece of music put you into another person’s experience, make you walk in their shoes?
- Emancipatory propaganda art - how do we emancipate ourselves through the act of creation and make visible the propaganda all around us - how do we turn it into
- Working with people - bringing out their potential and their super powers - what makes them unique, what only they can bring to a project to make it alive and magical
- When we work in community, in collective creation, everyone is empowered and the art becomes more alive, more magic when each person’s voice

Describe the context in which you work. You may choose to include information about your environment, community, artistic influences and cultural identity or, as relevant, your connection to OAC priority groups and how they have had an impact on you or your organization's art, career/development and decisions. [Maximum 300 words]

- priority groups - disabilities and living outside of Toronto city centre

List your group members or key staff, if applicable. The following information is required:
Name
Title or role

Type or upload your CV(s), resumé(s) and bio(s). [Maximum 1,000 words or 3 pages]

Enter the address for your website. robinmoir.com

Support Material

- Describe how the artistic examples below relate to your project. [Maximum 150 words]
- Provide the required artistic examples for this program.
- Upload the bios, CVs or organization summaries of your key project collaborators.
- Upload any other required support documents for this program.

Artistic examples

Describe how the artistic examples below relate to your project. (Maximum 150 words)

150 words left

Provide a minimum 2 artistic examples (mandatory).

You must provide a Professional Practice example and a Community-Engaged example.
If you are applying for additional mentorship funds, please include artistic examples of your mentee, and their mentor if this person is not the applicant.

Professional Practice Example(s)
(mandatory, maximum of 2.5 minutes of viewing, listening and/or reading material)

Example(s) should represent your work as an artist or that of the professional artist(s) involved in the project (this should not include examples of work as a facilitator)

Vid**eo (maximum 2)**

- Song for hephaestus chester playhouse
- Hephaestus shadowpuppet

Audio (maximum 2)
- Hephaestus Medley
- Norse Show

Images (maximum 10)
Note: 1 image counts as 15 seconds of viewing time.

Manuscript of literary material, music scores, scripts, zines, etc. (maximum 5 pages)
Note: 1 page counts as 30 seconds to 2 minutes reading time based on the nature of your material.
Tip: Do not include media reports, clippings, brochures, posters or promotional material (Exception: theatre artists may include programs, posters, etc. from past productions).
Note: File names must include the words "professional practice example".

- Setting the trap sheet music

Community-Engaged Example(s) (mandatory, maximum of 2.5 minutes of viewing, listening and/or reading material)

Example(s) should demonstrate the ability of the artist(s) involved in the project to facilitate community-engaged arts experiences. These could include examples of the final product and/or the creative process.

Video (maximum 2)
- Shadowland video
- Hephaestus fcyi & waldorf

Audio (maximum 2)

Images (maximum 10)
Note: 1 image counts as 15 seconds of viewing time.

Manuscript of literary material, music scores, scripts, zines, etc. (maximum 5 pages)
Note: 1 page counts as 30 seconds to 2 minutes reading time based on the nature of your material.
Tip: Do not include media reports, clippings, brochures, posters or promotional material.

- A song hephaestus children’s manuscript

Important: If you do not have community-engaged examples:

You must attach 2 letters of reference (maximum 1 page each) using the Manuscript upload.
Do not replace your community-engaged example with an additional professional practice example.
Note: File names must include the words "community-engaged example" or "letter of reference".

Sally's Artistic Highlights:
In 1985, Moved to Earlton with my partner to create a life-size moose and wolves sculpture carved out of cedar for the Northern Frontier Zoo
1987-Collaborated on a 10 metre high granite abstraction of a mine headframe with carved negative bas reliefs surrounded by 5 life-size figures of miners welded in mild steel and coated with bronze for the Miner's Memorial Foundation in Kirkland Lake. Completed in 1994
1996: Illustrated a book written by Chuck Angus and Britt Griffin, *The Life, Death, and Life of a Mining Town.* Archival photographs were collaged, painted and drawn to depict the passage of time
--1998: Welded 2 life-size figures of Mr. Schumacher and Sandy McIntyre for the Schumacher Revitalization Committee
-2000, collaborated on several bas relief sculptures in nickel-silver depicting miners from different historical eras for the Town of Cobalt. These sculptures were recently revitalized in 2023
-2001: Welded 3 life-size nickel-silver figures of different ages, genders and ethnic backgrounds to depict the diversity of the Brampton and Mississauga District workforce with a solar sculpture and labyrinth to commemorate the Day of Mourning for workers killed or injured on the job. Completed in 2013.

Education:
-1984: Graduated from the Ontario College of Art with honours
-1987: Graduated with a B.A. in Fine Art from the University of Guelph
-1988: Northern College Welding Course
-2001: Moved to Nova Scotia
-2006-2009: Taught several Summer and March Break Programs at the Ross Creek Centre for the Arts
-2008: Began teaching at the South Shore Waldorf School in Blockhouse, Nova Scotia
-2010: Graduated from the Rudolf Steiner Centre in Toronto as a trained Waldorf Grades Teacher
-2010-2014: Began working at the Toronto Waldorf School as a Lead Grades Teacher
-2014-2025: Taught at the Toronto Waldorf School Summer Camp as a Lead Kindergarten Teacher
-2015: Graduated from York University with a Bachelors of Education
-2015- 2026: Private Tutor - English and Art
-2023: Began working part-time at The Forest Courtyard Initiative
-Currently work as a Full-time Lead Grades teacher at The Forest Courtyard initiative

Grants:
Artists in the Workplace (1990s) 3 grants
Artists in the Schools (1990s) 2 grants

Mentoring:
I have much to offer as a mentor because of my 45 years working as an artist and teacher and my wealth of experience as a collaborator on large projects. I have collaborated on sculptures and murals and have worked on art and poetry projects with groups of students. I enjoy how the end result is always greater than the sum of its parts and how something magical happens when people join together to share and uncover their talents to create something bigger than themselves. The result is unpredictable and exciting because it evolves within the community it expresses. I have worked with Labour, Arts, and educational organizations on huge projects where timelines and budgets must be adhered to.

Liaison:
I was a professional artist who has taught a wide variety of ages of children and adults, so I welcome the role of liaison between the artist and school. Also, I have lived at Hesperus and have enjoyed its unique and vital senior community for 17 years. I look forward to working on a multi-generational arts project with the residents. Bringing elderly people together with children is an exciting notion that I believe would be mutually beneficial to both communities. Children will be encouraged to uncover blossoming talents and older people will have the opportunity to revisit or discover gifts that may be lying below the surface.

Budget

Fill in OAC's project budget form. Your budget must balance at $0 (total expenses equal total revenues).

Type or upload budget notes. [Maximum 1,000 words if using text box]

Priorities

The program's priorities are to support projects that:

- work with sectors beyond the arts, such as health, education, justice and the environment
- provide a sense of community, social connection, civic engagement and contribute to building a more just society
- reduce barriers to arts participation
- increase access to the arts for underserved or marginalized communities
- employ Ontario artists in Ontario communities

Deadline date(s)

April 21 and October 15, 2026, 1 p.m. ET

The application form will be available in Nova about two months before the deadline. You will find out whether you got a grant about four and a half months after each deadline.

Grant amount(s)

Planning: maximum $7,500
Project: maximum $12,500
Two-year project: maximum $20,000

Important:

Up to $3,000 in additional funds are available in any category for mentorship costs of both mentees and mentors.

Eligible applicants

- professional artists, including co-applicants, who are Ontario residents
- ad hoc groups and collectives that have 50 per cent of its members residing in Ontario

Ontario-based not-for-profit arts organizations and non-arts organizations
school boards not partnered in OAC's Artists in Residence (Education) program (for artist fees and travel expenses only)
schools run by First Nations or Indigenous education authorities

Important: Non-arts organizations, schools run by First Nations or Indigenous education authorities, and school boards must have an arts partner. Arts partners can be professional artists, arts collectives, ad hoc arts groups, or arts organizations.

Read the Guide to OAC Project Programs for more eligibility information.

What this program funds

projects that actively include community participants in the creation and production of artistic works
artists' fees
support specialist fees (including translators, Elders, therapists, etc.)
honoraria for project participants
snack and beverage expenses for participants
travel expenses
venue or studio rental
purchase of small-scale equipment, software, electronics and similar materials required to carry out the project
materials costs
administrative costs associated with the artists or arts ad hoc group, collective or organization only
marketing, outreach and promotion expenses
childcare and other dependant care fees enabling individuals to take part in the project (this does not include regular, ongoing expenses)
expenses related to making the project accessible to audience members and project participants (other than the applicant) who are Deaf or have a disability

Note: Applicants to this program who identify as Deaf or as having a disability may apply for supplementary funds for their own accessibility expenses through Accessibility Fund: Project Support.

Access: People, regardless of geographic, racial, social, economic or physical realities have equal opportunity to experience the arts and participate in cultural life.

Co-creation: A process to create a final product where non-artists and professional artist(s) work side-by-side and have equal input and impact on the outcome.

Letters of confirmation or intent: Letters confirming participation in the current project must be written by either the arts or non-arts partner(s) on the project who is/are not the applicant are a mandatory item(s). Non-arts community applicants must include letters from their arts partners or artists. Arts applicants must include letters from their non-arts community partner(s) or groups.

Letters must confirm participation in the current project with relevant time period. Letters may additionally speak to community relationship, contribution to the project, expected impacts and value of the project, etc. All letters must be signed, and ideally be written on letterhead. Do not include reference letters. If you cannot get a partner letter, it is recommended that you wait to apply to the next deadline.